SREENIDHI MODEL UNITED NATIONS

SMUN 2026 | COMMITTEE BACKGROUND GUIDE

UNITED NATIONS HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL

UNHRC

United Nations Human Rights Council

COMMITTEE AGENDA

Strengthening International Cooperation for the Promotion and Protection of the Rights of Women and Girls in the Context of Digital Technologies

Equality • Dignity • International Cooperation

Message from the Secretariat

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to Sreenidhi Model United Nations 2026. The Secretariat is pleased to welcome you to the United Nations Human Rights Council, where you will consider the promotion and protection of the rights of women and girls in an increasingly interconnected digital world.

Technology can expand access to education, livelihood opportunities, information and public participation. At the same time, digital exclusion, technology-facilitated violence, threats to privacy and discriminatory automated systems present urgent questions of dignity, equality and accountability. The challenge before this Council is to develop principled, feasible responses that recognise both the opportunities and the risks of technological change.

This Background Guide provides a foundation for informed debate. It introduces the Council, explains the agenda and its historical and legal context, examines contemporary challenges and international responses, and sets out questions for further investigation. It should complement, rather than replace, independent research into the documented policies and international commitments of each assigned Member State.

We encourage delegates to approach differing national perspectives with intellectual rigour, diplomatic courtesy and an understanding of the Council's institutional mandate. Effective resolutions should identify clear responsibilities, realistic mechanisms of implementation and safeguards that protect fundamental rights.

We look forward to thoughtful debate, substantive cooperation and proposals that place human dignity at the centre of international action.

Warm regards,
The Secretariat
Sreenidhi Model United Nations 2026

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A guide to informed research, human-rights-centred diplomacy and practical committee deliberation.

01 Introduction to the Committee

The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC or the Council) is the principal intergovernmental forum within the United Nations system dedicated to the promotion and protection of human rights. Established by General Assembly Resolution 60/251 on 15 March 2006, it succeeded the former Commission on Human Rights. The Council comprises 47 Member States elected by the General Assembly, with seats allocated across five regional groups. It meets to address human rights situations, advance international standards and encourage dialogue and cooperation between states.

The Council operates through several complementary mechanisms. The Universal Periodic Review (UPR) examines the human rights records of all United Nations Member States on a recurring basis; Special Procedures mandate holders, including Special Rapporteurs and independent experts, investigate thematic or country-specific issues; and Council-authorised fact-finding missions and commissions of inquiry may examine serious alleged violations. The Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR) supports much of this work. The Council also interacts with, but is institutionally distinct from, independent treaty-monitoring bodies, including the Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women.

Its authority is primarily deliberative, investigative and recommendatory. The UNHRC may adopt resolutions, request reports, establish certain mandates and facilitate scrutiny, but it does not function as a criminal court and cannot itself enact universally binding domestic rules or directly compel technology companies to comply with new regulatory standards. Effective outcomes therefore depend on national implementation, international cooperation and engagement with United Nations agencies, civil society and private actors.

The present agenda belongs squarely within this mandate. Discrimination, violence, privacy violations and barriers to participation can be reproduced or intensified through digital systems. At the same time, technology can expand access to education, work, healthcare, civic participation and justice. The Council's significance lies in its capacity to frame these problems as questions of human rights, bring different national experiences into a common discussion and recommend responses that protect both online safety and fundamental freedoms.

"for her efforts for democracy and human rights. She has focused especially on the struggle for the rights of women and children" — Nobel Committee's motivation for the 2003 Peace Prize awarded to Shirin Ebadi

02 Introduction to the Agenda

Digital technologies shape how people learn, communicate, earn a livelihood, receive public services and exercise political rights. Affordable internet access, digital financial tools and online learning can widen opportunities for women and girls who have historically faced exclusion from public institutions and markets. Yet digital transformation does not automatically produce equality: pre-existing disparities in income, education, safety, mobility and social power may determine who benefits from innovation and who bears its risks.

The agenda—"Strengthening International Cooperation for the Promotion and Protection of the Rights of Women and Girls in the Context of Digital Technologies"—asks delegates to consider two interconnected goals. The first is inclusion: enabling women and girls to access and meaningfully use digital technology. The second is protection: ensuring that participation does not expose them to discrimination, intimidation, exploitation, unjustified surveillance or other violations of human rights. Neither objective should be pursued at the expense of the other.

These problems frequently cross national borders. A platform may be incorporated in one country, store information in another, and serve users elsewhere. Online abuse may involve anonymous or coordinated actors, while artificial intelligence systems may be trained on data that reflects biases originating in multiple societies. Differences in domestic laws, institutional capacity and regulatory approaches make cooperation essential; however, international measures must still respect privacy, due process, freedom of expression and the needs of women and girls with different circumstances.

Delegates should approach the agenda as a question of practical governance rather than treating all technology as inherently harmful or assuming that all regulation is protective. The central task is to identify interventions that are rights-based, proportionate, affordable, enforceable and attentive to local conditions.

03 Explanation of the Agenda

3.1 Historical Context: Women's Rights and the Digital Transformation

The international movement for women's equal rights long predates the digital age. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948) affirmed equality and fundamental freedoms, while the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (1979) established a binding framework for states parties to eliminate discrimination. The Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action (1995) further identified women's access to communication systems and participation in media as matters of equality and empowerment. These instruments provide an essential foundation for understanding rights in digital environments.

As internet connectivity, mobile communications and platform-based services expanded, opportunities for education, employment, political participation and access to information developed alongside new forms of exclusion and abuse. International discussions increasingly recognised that existing rights do not disappear when their exercise moves online. The central question is not whether women and girls should receive a separate category of digital rights, but how established rights can be realised and effectively protected amid rapidly changing technologies.

3.2 The digital gender divide: access, skills and meaningful participation

The digital gender divide extends beyond whether a person owns a phone or has an internet connection. It encompasses the affordability of devices and data, reliability of infrastructure, literacy and language accessibility, digital skills, social restrictions on technology use, and the ability to participate securely in online education, employment and public life. A woman may be technically connected but still lack the privacy, confidence or resources needed to use that connection effectively.

The barriers are often compounded for women and girls in rural communities, low-income households, displacement settings and other underserved populations, as well as for persons with disabilities. A serious inclusion policy therefore requires more than numerical connectivity targets. Delegates should examine community-based training, accessible design, affordable connectivity, safe public access points, gender-responsive education and the collection of disaggregated data with appropriate privacy safeguards.

3.3 Technology-facilitated gender-based violence

Technology-facilitated gender-based violence can include threats, cyberstalking, repeated harassment, identity-based abuse, impersonation, doxxing, non-consensual dissemination of intimate images and the use of digital tools for coercive control. Such conduct can inflict psychological, reputational, professional and financial harm. The consequences can extend beyond the screen: victims may withdraw from education, journalism, politics or economic activity to avoid further exposure.

Digital systems can magnify abuse through rapid replication, anonymity, networked harassment and the difficulty of securing the permanent removal of harmful material. Policies must distinguish unlawful threats, exploitation and non-consensual material from lawful but unpopular speech. Possible responses include accessible complaint pathways, timely platform intervention, victim-centred assistance, evidence-preservation procedures, specialist law-enforcement training and remedies subject to appropriate judicial oversight.

3.4 Artificial intelligence, algorithmic discrimination and synthetic media

Automated decision-making can affect recruitment, lending, public benefits, advertising and the distribution of information. If design choices or training datasets encode historical inequalities, seemingly neutral systems may produce discriminatory outcomes. The risks may be particularly severe where affected individuals cannot understand why a decision was made or challenge an inaccurate result. Gender-sensitive impact assessments, testing across relevant population groups, auditability and meaningful human review merit consideration.

Generative artificial intelligence creates additional challenges, including realistic synthetic images, audio and video used for impersonation or sexualised abuse. Responses should consider prevention, clear reporting routes, restrictions on harmful non-consensual content, preservation of lawful expression, transparency about synthetic media and remedies for affected individuals. Delegates should avoid assuming that a single technical tool can eliminate these risks or that automatic detection is error-free.

3.5 Privacy, data protection and the protection of children

Women and girls may face distinctive risks when personal information concerning their identity, location, health, intimate lives or family circumstances is collected, disclosed or misused. Weak security and excessive surveillance can discourage them from accessing important services or speaking freely. Safeguards should address data minimisation, purpose limitation, secure storage, meaningful consent where appropriate, lawful processing, independent oversight and effective avenues for complaint.

Girls require particular attention because age, power imbalances and developmental needs may make them more vulnerable to grooming, exploitation, profiling and harmful design practices. The Convention on the Rights of the Child is relevant alongside standards concerning equality and privacy. Measures designed to protect children should themselves be assessed for risks, including intrusive age-verification methods, discriminatory exclusion, unnecessary collection of identity documents and restrictions that inadvertently limit legitimate access to education or information.

3.6 Current Challenges: A Changing Landscape of Digital Harm

New tools and business models can intensify longstanding inequalities. Generative AI can be misused to create non-consensual intimate images and impersonation content; coordinated harassment can be amplified by recommendation systems; and gaps in language support, moderation and access to reporting mechanisms may impede remedies. The availability of affordable devices and connectivity does not by itself guarantee digital literacy, safety or meaningful participation.

The cross-border character of platforms presents additional problems of jurisdiction, preservation of evidence and enforcement. Measures that seek to address abuse may themselves create risks if they rely on indiscriminate surveillance, vague censorship powers or excessive collection of sensitive information. Delegates should distinguish documented harms from assumptions about technological impacts and evaluate policies by reference to necessity, proportionality, accessibility and accountability.

3.7 International human rights standards and institutional responsibilities

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights articulates principles of equality, privacy, expression, education and participation. Binding treaty obligations arise under instruments to which states are parties, including the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR), the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW), and the Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC). The application of particular treaty obligations depends on each state's treaty participation and any relevant reservations.

CEDAW requires states parties to address discrimination against women and to pursue substantive equality across social, political and economic life; the CRC supplies additional protections relevant to girls. The Council's role is to promote dialogue, review state practice and recommend measures consistent with these standards. UN Women, OHCHR, UNICEF, the International Telecommunication Union and other competent organisations may support implementation within their respective mandates. These bodies perform different functions and should not be treated as interchangeable enforcement agencies.

"for their efforts to safeguard freedom of expression, which is a precondition for democracy and lasting peace" — Nobel Committee's motivation for the 2021 Peace Prize awarded jointly to Maria Ressa and Dmitry Muratov

3.8 Platform accountability, remedies and freedom of expression

Governments and technology companies face difficult questions about responsibility for online abuse. A credible approach should ask whether users can understand platform rules, report violations without unreasonable burdens, receive timely decisions, appeal mistaken takedowns and secure assistance where serious threats arise. Transparency reporting and independent evaluation may help assess the effectiveness and unintended consequences of moderation and safety tools.

Human rights safeguards are indispensable. Broad censorship powers, indiscriminate monitoring or vague offences may suppress the very voices that protective measures are intended to empower. Interventions affecting speech or privacy should be grounded in law and evaluated for legitimacy, necessity and proportionality, with independent review and remedies against wrongful decisions. Delegates should account for the power imbalance between platforms and individual users without treating public authority as immune from misuse.

3.9 Current International Response and Areas for Cooperation

The United Nations human rights system addresses these concerns through several complementary channels. The Human Rights Council examines equality, discrimination, privacy and online freedom of expression; OHCHR provides analysis and technical support; UN Women advances gender equality initiatives; and UNICEF contributes expertise on children's rights and digital safety. Treaty bodies, the Universal Periodic Review and relevant Special Procedures can also inform states' policies and implementation.

At the broader international level, the Beijing framework, the Sustainable Development Goals and ongoing international discussions of digital cooperation offer bases for policy coordination. The Global Digital Compact adopted in 2024 sets out shared objectives for an inclusive, open, safe and secure digital future, including attention to human rights and gender equality. Such political commitments should be distinguished from binding treaty obligations and evaluated in light of national implementation.

Practical cooperation may include transparent reporting channels, privacy-protective evidence-sharing, assistance to national human rights institutions, digital literacy programmes, accessible survivor support, independent assessment of high-risk AI systems and cooperation with technology companies and civil society. Proposals should specify who implements each measure, how resources are mobilised and how progress will be measured.

3.10 Cross-border cooperation and institutional capacity

Investigating online harm may require cooperation where evidence, service providers and affected persons are situated in different jurisdictions. Difficulties include inconsistent offences and procedural rules, delays in obtaining evidence, confidentiality obligations and unequal investigative resources. Cooperative frameworks may support lawful preservation requests, contact points, judicial assistance, shared technical standards and training, but safeguards must prevent arbitrary disclosure, misuse of sensitive information or circumvention of due process.

Capacity-building is as important as standard-setting. Some states may require technical support to establish effective cybercrime units, data-protection authorities, accessible complaint systems or digital-literacy programmes. International cooperation should also include meaningful consultation with women's rights organisations, child-protection experts, educators, technology firms and affected communities. Delegates should consider who will finance programmes, how institutions will coordinate and what measurable results will indicate progress.

3.11 From international commitments to implementable solutions

Resolutions should contain a clear allocation of responsibility rather than relying on declarations of concern. Proposed measures might recommend national action plans, gender-responsive digital-skills programmes, victim-support services, transparent platform reporting, rights-respecting cooperation on digital evidence, voluntary technical assistance and periodic evaluation. For each proposal, delegates should identify the implementing institution, necessary resources, intended beneficiaries and means of independent review.

Evaluation requires indicators that capture both access and safety: for example, differences in digital participation, availability of accessible reporting systems, response times, access to remedies and the experience of affected groups. Such data should be interpreted cautiously and collected without compromising privacy. Importantly, the Council may recommend and facilitate these initiatives, while domestic authorities and other institutions must exercise their own legal powers to carry them out.

04 Reference Links and Resources

The following reference links have been restored from the original UNHRC background document. Delegates are encouraged to use primary sources for legal instruments and official national positions, and to verify the publication dates of research and reporting.

01. International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC)

Humanitarian protection and the effects of armed conflict on civilians, including women and girls.

02. Reuters

Current reporting on technology policy, online safety, human rights and international developments.

03. World Bank - Gender and Inclusion in Digital

Research on digital inclusion, access to connectivity, digital skills and women's economic participation.

04. Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF)

Humanitarian perspectives on vulnerable communities and the protection of women and girls in crisis settings.

05. United Nations Human Rights Council

Official information on the Human Rights Council's mandate, membership, sessions and mechanisms.

06. UN Women

Policy research and UN initiatives on gender equality and technology-facilitated violence.

07. Nobel Prize - Peace Prize Laureates

Information for checking attributed Nobel Peace Prize quotations and award motivations.

05 Questions to Consider

Delegates should investigate the documented position of their assigned country, its relevant treaty commitments and domestic laws, and the practical consequences of the measures it may propose. The following questions are intended to inform research, moderated debate and draft resolutions.

01. What are the principal barriers to meaningful digital access for women and girls in the country represented, and which groups face compounded disadvantages?

02. Which forms of technology-facilitated gender-based violence require the most urgent response, and how can prevention, victim support and legal remedies work together?

03. How can states cooperate to investigate cross-border online abuse while respecting sovereignty, lawful process, data protection and individual rights?

04. What responsibilities should digital platforms and technology developers assume, and which responsibilities properly belong to states or independent oversight bodies?

05. How should algorithmic discrimination and misuse of AI-generated intimate or deceptive content be assessed, documented and addressed?

06. How can laws designed to prevent online harm avoid disproportionate restrictions on freedom of expression, privacy and access to information?

07. What special protections are appropriate for girls, and how can child-safety measures avoid unnecessary surveillance or exclusion?

08. Which obligations arise from the international instruments binding on the assigned country, and which initiatives remain policy recommendations rather than legal duties?

09. How can international support reduce inequalities in infrastructure, devices, digital literacy and institutional enforcement capacity?

10. What roles can the UNHRC, OHCHR, UN Women, UNICEF, national human rights institutions and civil society realistically perform?

11. How can survivors access affordable, confidential, trauma-informed reporting and remedies, including where perpetrators or platforms are outside their jurisdiction?

12. What indicators, funding commitments and review mechanisms would allow the Council to assess whether cooperation has improved both safety and equality?

13. How should delegates reconcile differing national priorities while developing language capable of securing broad support within the Council?